Sweet Eros

By Terrence McNally

YOUNG MAN: So there's really no reason it was you. Once I'd made my mind up, it could have been anyone. You just happened to cross my path before the next person. *(He lowers his eyes.)* I said there'd be no lies. *(He looks up at her.)* It couldn't have been just anyone. I wouldn't have taken a child or an older person. Someone in a religious order. A handicapped person, A lot of people I wouldn't have taken. I wanted a girl.

INTRODUCTION

A disturbed young man, soured by two failed romantic relationships, has kidnapped a young woman (a complete stranger). The woman is seated in a chair, bound and gagged as the man explains his reasons for kidnapping her, and what he's come to realize about life and love. His goal? To force the woman to understand him - and, ultimately, to submit to him. Sweet Eros by Terrence McNally

YOUNG MAN: So I suppose it was inevitable. I mean when you want to do something that bad that long, sooner or later you do it. And I wanted this for a long time. It started off just being an idea . . . one of those cool, safe abstractions that never got anybody into trouble ... the whole plan just seemed so damned risky! Not unreasonable, mind you, but risky. You can imagine: the police, the one chance in a million of hurting you, morning-after remorse on my part. The same things that cross a murderer's mind probably. And then yesterday morning, overnight, just like that, I woke up thinking. "What the

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hell?" I'm young, reasonable-looking, clean--certainly I wouldn't terrify her and maybe she'll like me by the time it's over. I'm rich enough-so there's money when it's done if she's got hard feelings. I'm in the country-no chance of neighbors hearing if I took the gag off too soon. And I'm a good person. Mmm. I like myself. That's important. So I took the car, drove into the city, saw you walking your dog (I assume it was yours), and here you are. Easy. *(He lowers his eyes, then raises them.)* I had to kill the dog. *(The Girl struggles.)* He barked. *(The Girl continues to struggle.)* HE BARKED! *(The Girl stops struggling.)* He was a nice dog. I'm sorry he barked. *(He smiles. Slow blackout.)*

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YOUNG MAN: If you really look at another person, you'll find they're rather strange. Oh, I recognize the physical resemblance, but after hair, nose, eyes, mouth, teeth, neck, arms, legs and all, it stops. The resemblance, I mean. Know what I mean? *(He smiles)* I think insects are less strange to one another than people are. Take ants. An ant either really accepts another ant or he doesn't even think about it. The point is, they cooperate. There's no friction with ants. They make do. Then take people: they don't accept each other, which is fact number one about them, and fact number two, that's *all* they think about. So there's noncooperation, friction. Let's face it: humans are tense together. *(He takes off her shoes.)*

My first woman . . . notice I don't say wife . . . was so fraught she

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couldn't cope at all. They carted her off eventually. And yet you'd have thought she had everything going for her: good background, a big fat inheritance after a touching reunion with her daddy on his deathbed; a spiffy career and me. I include myself in this girl's cornucopia because I loved her. I mean she was lucky. Somebody *cared* and, sister, there aren't words enough to tell how much I loved this person. *(He is taking off her stockings now.)* Sounds ideal, no? For her, I mean. Well, there was a fly in this girl's ointment, and he had two arms, two legs, and his name was me. She couldn't stand me. No, I'm confusing you. She could stand *me;* it was my love for her she couldn't stand. This was a girl who could not bear to be loved. I loved her. It should have been enough. At least it should have mattered. *(He starts to unbutton her blouse.)*

So there we were. Me loving her; her ... liking me, and every day the worse it got. She took to drinking, ridiculing my work (I was teaching the new math at the time), *(He has worked her blouse down over her bound arms.)* Oh, did we ever scrap! *(He takes off her bra.)* Real knockdown-drag-outs. Name calling, doors slamming, the works. Only trouble was I'd feel just rotten every time I landed her a good rap on the mouth. I'd help her up, walk her to the bathroom, clean the blood up. It used to ruin my evenings. God, it was frustrating. *(He is working her skirt down over her ankles.)* Anyway, years passed like this. Three, to be exact. And then there was this one morning. I woke up and thought to myself, "I've had it." So I dressed, left her a note and never saw her again. *(He pulls down her half-slip.)* They say she woke up about four that afternoon found the note and promptly

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went berserk. She went into a deep and swift decline and was eventually committed to an asylum somewhere upstate. *(Short pause.)* But she'd taught me a lesson. People ... and I didn't include myself . . . people don't like to be loved. *(He removes her panties.)*

My second woman ... well, she taught me something, too. When we met, soon after my famous note, she was young, successful (she modeled; pick up any issue of one of those magazines and there she was), and beautiful. It hurt to look at her. And the cherry on the icing was this: this Venus loved me! *(Pause.)* So now I had everything going for *me*. I was adored! I mean this girl was put on earth for no other purpose than to love. She hand-laundered my shirts and then she ironed them and put them on hangers. She shined shoes, this girl! But she was more than a domestic, you understand. I'd given up teaching and started writing by then. She helped me! She wouldn't just read the poems and smile and nod her head. No, she'd take a pencil and make x's, change words, edit, everything! When the work was good she made me feel like a king. When it wasn't she'd tell me why and I'd still feel like the best poet who ever lived. She inspired poetry! *(Pause.)*

Our nights were nearly perfect, our sleep like two cubs cuddled, our mornings a time for the dearest laughter, Our days productive and meaningful and our evenings so quiet and gentle alone together that she lost all desire to see other people. *(Short pause.)* A different girl, a different ointment, but the same fly, alas. I couldn't stand her loving me. Here I had everything I wanted ... well, everything I

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thought I wanted ... and I didn't want it at all. This time I didn't leave a note. I told her to her face. "I don't love you.". . . and the next morning she helped me pack my things. She kissed me when I left . . .

I waited until about six that evening before calling her to see how she was getting on. I was glad when she didn't answer. The next night, again no answer. I didn't even feel guilty any more. About the sixth day I began to get worried. By the tenth day I forgot all about the pros and cons of it and just went over there. I had this terribly strong desire to make sure she was all right. Know what I mean? I suspected the worst but it was more terrible than that. She was lying on the bed, the bottle of pills on the floor beside her. The cat looked up startled when I entered the bedroom and scurried away. He'd eaten away a good deal of her face, you see, naturally there'd been no one to feed him, and I guess he knew he was in for a spanking. I called the police. There was an autopsy, cause of death listed as probably suicide and a rather shabbily attended funeral. But then she hadn't wanted friends after me. *(Short pause.)*

Since then I've lived alone out here in envy of the ants. I think I understand them. People just ... seem strange to me. People ... and since her too I've had to include myself . . . people don't like to be loved.

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The Girl is in the chair. The Man finds his latest manuscript and reads.

YOUNG MAN: It's good, it's very good. I'm going to be famous. *(Reading over what he has written.)* "The girl is sitting in the chair. For days now there has been no rope. She accepts the life we share." *(He frowns; then crosses out with a pencil)* Goddamn it, I don't know if you accept! *(Reads again.)* "The girl is sitting in the chair. For days now there has been no rope." Period. *(He smiles)* That's more like it. *(He puts the page away.)* I guess you'd like your little late-night newscast. Let's see. It was cold out. Oh, there was sun all right, but not enough for shadows. They've made a cancer breakthrough. Someone prominent died. Oh! This is of interest. The newspapers have forgotten all about you. There wasn't even a mention this evening.

Oh God, I am so deliriously happy! After all, this is how I always imagined it. I have everything I want now. It will be years before I'm done with you (maybe a lifetime) but you can't imagine how much less strange your body already is to me. Sometimes I look across the room at you and feel I almost know you.. How much better words unspoken are! You're happy here, I can tell. Why, your eyes are glowing, you're almost purring. You belong to someone and that's a good feeling. There's no strain left, we're coexisting, that's better than love. Besides, people don't like to he loved. Just go on breathing, staying at 98.6 and you'll have everything you want.

(He sees something on the floor.) Come on, sweetheart, up you go! *(He has let an ant crawl onto his hand.)* Look. My friend, the ant.

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Once you understand them, all ants are beautiful, hut this one's especially fine. Look at him struggling, thrashing about, trying to find his way! You're in a little frenzy, aren't you there? I see the little legs going, the antennae twitching a mile a minute. *(Moving his hand all the time to keep the ant from crawling up his arm.)* Go ahead, exhaust yourself. It's hopeless, but how long before you realize that and settle down in the palm of my hand? It's not worth struggling. Look, he can't stop! His death throes and he doesn't know it. I know what you're thinking, ant: "I'm lost, hut I'll find my way. I won't give up the fight. It's worth my effort. Keep struggling, keep the legs going, the heart beating, and I'll find my way to something better. Don't give up, that's the main thing, don't give up!" Isn't that what you're thinking, ant? I'M NOT GOING TO DIE. NOT YET. NOT ME." *(He lets the ant escape)*

It's time I thought of a name for you. Laura. Would you like Laura? You don't have to answer now. We're not ready for talking to each other yet. It will come . . . in time . . . everything does. I have everything I want now. Everything!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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